

Geography of Colombian Life Satisfaction

Sunday 26th April, 2026 12:06

XXX TODO ADD TO EBIB AS KEYWORD PAPER-CODE-NAME AND TAG WITH EBIB KEYWORDS

This paper is about geography of Colombian happiness.¹ We start with departments/provinces, then move to cities/municipalities, and finally finish up with urban-rural and farmers.

about colombia boilerplate like 2nd biggest land mas and pop in lat am? one of the happiest that table from fools paradise

and need about geography like goog 'gepgraphy of colombia' in goog scholar and normal goog

about roads etc ranked one of thw worst and airports

We know little about colombian happiness: my paper, stiupid burger as cited in my paper, and that govt report i cite in my paper!!
do skim thru it!!

1 Data

We use a great source of data ECV. We use 2023 edition.

2 Departments/Provinces

there are 166k missing out of 242k, we conduct robustness check in appendix using 2021 wave

the map is below, table including number of obserrvations per province is in appendix

unhappy: West (poor Choco, and Southern Cauca and Narino) and East Guainia and Vichada. In 2021 (see appendix) Choco and Cauca were still relatively unhappy, but slightly happier.

Happy caffetero: Caldas, Risaralda, Quindio—in 2021 there were slight differences (see appendix) but overall Caffetero was happy too. And also happy Santander. Then slightly less happy Norte de Santander, Cesar and Atlantico. In 2021 (see appendix) Santander, Cesar and Atlantico were less happy.

¹Following usual practice in social indicators research terms happiness and life satisfaction are used interhcangeably, and specifically we mean cognitive and evaluative life satisfaction rather than affective happiness.

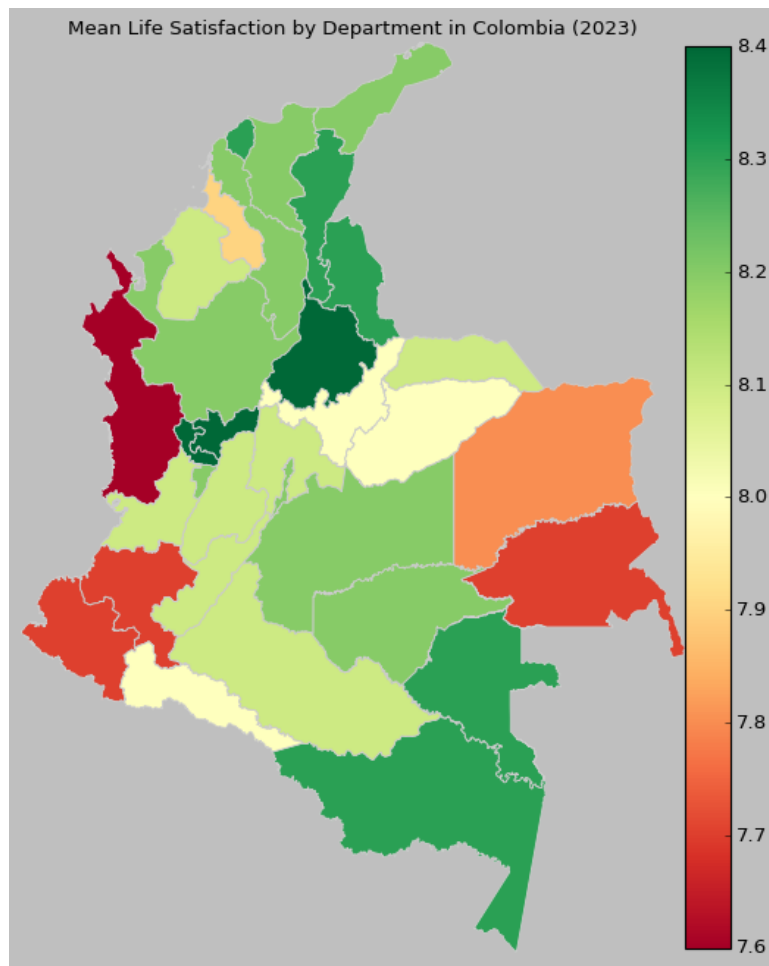


Figure 1: Similar to 2021 robustness/sensitivity check in appendix except: small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, both South-Eastern at 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Second largest differences: Santander and Putumayo increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

3 Cities/Municipalities

166k/242k missing, again robustness/sensitivity check in appendix with 2021 ecv

Acacías	8.3
Aguazul	8.1
Armenia	8.1
Barrancabermeja	8.6
Barranquilla	8.3
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2
Bucaramanga	8.6
Buenaventura	8.1
Calarcá	8.4
Cali	8.0
Cartagena	8.2
Ciénaga	8.4
Cúcuta	8.3
Florencia	8.2
Ibagué	8.4
Malambo	8.3
Manizales	8.4
Medellín	8.4
Montería	8.3
Neiva	8.3
Palmira	7.9
Pasto	7.9
Pereira	8.4
Pitalito	8.0
Popayán	7.9
Puerto Carreño	7.5
San José del Guaviare	8.1
Santa Marta	8.3
Sincelejo	8.1
Sogamoso	8.2
Tulúa	8.2
Tunja	7.9
Valledupar	8.0
Villavicencio	8.2
Yopal	8.3

Figure 2

2 santander cities shine

Armenia Manizales, coffee happier

just 20 or so ¿300 obs for 2023 and in appendix 140 or so ¿100 obs for 2023 and 2021

4 Urban-Rural and Farmers

While most developed countries cities are unhappy and indeed unhappy city is a common pattern across the world (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021), it is not always the case in developing countries.

here boilerplate from happy col unhappyy bog: that cities are growth engines Glaeser (2011) and O'Sullivan (2009) and developing countries like colombia do need economic growth hence role for cities is greater than in already developed countries

and there is paradox of happy peasant and unhappy millionaire Graham (2009)

though not so much in colombia, urban and rural are about same happy, except by income: bar chart by income category bu urb rur as in raman

ONLINE APPENDIX (Supplementary Online Material (SOM))

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead]

```
. tabstat ls, by(lwd7) stat(mean sd) format(%9.1f)
```

Summary for variables: ls
Group variable: lwd7 (RECODE of lwd (do what you like))

lwd7	Mean	SD
0-4	5.6	2.7
2	7.6	2.3
3	7.6	1.8
4	8.0	1.5
5	7.8	1.9
6	8.2	1.5
7	8.9	1.5
Total	8.3	1.9

.9

5 Reestimation Using 2023 ECV

2021 May be biased say bc of covid, especially that it peaked in colombia in 2021 <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/region/columbia>(by 2023 used in the paper it pretty much cleared). But it a useful robustness check, if covid didnt change much , then it should be pretty stable

and it was quite high mortality in col <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/data/mortality>

5.1 Departments/Provinces

Again as said in the paper, overall results are similar to 2023 reported in the body of the paper, except small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, both South-Eastern and with 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Sencond largest differences are for Santander and Putumayo which increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

Table 1: Life satisfaction by department.

department	life isfaction 2023	sat- total 2023	obs	non- missing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	total 2021	obs	non non ing satisfaction 2021	miss- life satisfaction	2023-2021
Amazonas	8.3	276	245	7.6	423	365	0.7			
Antioquia	8.2	5499	4729	8.3	6036	5060	-0.1			
Arauca	8.1	974	773	8.1	1103	868	0			
Atlántico	8.3	3144	2311	8.0	2338	1799	0.3			
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	4688	3446	8.1	5337	3810	0.1			
Bolívar	8.2	2584	2258	8.1	2495	2156	0.1			
Boyacá	8.0	4129	3649	7.8	4638	4122	0.2			
Caldas	8.4	2822	2555	8.2	3335	3005	0.2			
Caquetá	8.1	2547	2018	7.9	2846	2249	0.2			
Casanare	8.0	1749	1370	8.1	2051	1457	-0.1			
Cauca	7.7	2580	2244	7.9	2572	2287	-0.2			
Cesar	8.3	2224	1717	8.0	1833	1510	0.3			
Chocó	7.6	857	754	7.9	1016	913	-0.3			
Cundinamarca	8.1	3818	3322	7.8	4233	3684	0.3			
Córdoba	8.1	2706	2240	8.0	2226	1933	0.1			
Guainía	7.7	327	273	7.4	350	274	0.3			
Guaviare	8.2	700	457	8.0	621	411	0.2			
Huila	8.1	2961	2322	8.0	2999	2407	0.1			
La Guajira	8.2	951	750	7.9	988	736	0.3			
Magdalena	8.2	2458	2096	8.0	2110	1710	0.2			
Meta	8.2	3683	2752	8.1	3862	2817	0.1			
Nariño	7.7	2284	2034	7.4	2847	2492	0.3			
Norte de Santander	8.3	2499	2028	8.2	2587	2171	0.1			
Putumayo	8.0	950	752	7.6	1272	1012	0.4			
Quindío	8.2	2085	1658	8.4	2186	1785	-0.2			
Risaralda	8.4	1634	1353	8.3	1996	1663	0.1			
San Andrés y Providencia	8.4	28	25	8.2	29	26	0.2			
Santander	8.4	3790	3194	8.0	4153	3574	0.4			
Sucre	7.9	1798	1399	7.8	1899	1467	0.1			
Tolima	8.1	3564	3215	8.0	4257	3770	0.1			
Valle del Cauca	8.1	4892	4093	8.1	5268	4421	0			
Vaupés	8.3	265	245	7.6	288	267	0.7			
Vichada	7.8	515	455	7.6	584	482	0.2			

5.2 Cities/Municipalities

5.3 Urban-Rural and Farmers

References

- GLAESER, E. (2011): *Triumph of the City: How Our Greatest Invention Makes Us Richer, Smarter, Greener, Healthier, and Happier*, Penguin Press, New York NY.
- GRAHAM, C. (2009): *Happiness around the world: The paradox of happy peasants and miserable millionaires*, Oxford University Press, New York NY.
- OKULICZ-KOZARYN, A. AND R. R. VALENTE (2021): "Urban unhappiness is common," *Cities*, 103368.
- O'SULLIVAN, A. (2009): *Urban economics*, McGraw-Hill.